



losers, in the realm of teams with European experience and high-profile stars, into oblivion. Instead, the errant nature of the sport made way for stories of fortitude and joy from unexpected corners.

Palestine — a country in peril through constant bombardment from Israel, and with families of several of its players facing an uncertain fate — scripted history. It beat Hong Kong 3-0 in its final group-stage match and made it to the round of 16, earning a win and a knockout spot for the first time.

Jordan, one of the lowest-ranked sides to ever reach the final (87th), beat sides ranked 24 and 54 spots higher (Iraq and South Korea, respectively) on its way.

The Nashama did not have Son Heung Mins or Mehdi Taremis but still persevered, working as a well-oiled machine under coach Hussein Ammouta despite a debilitated infrastructure back home.

Showstopper: Qatar saw different leaders step up in different games, starting with Akram Afif, who scored a hat-trick in the final, making runs along flanks and feeding long balls for set-pieces. AFP

The most prominent story, however, was that of Tajikistan, the only debutant and one of the lowest-ranked teams. With its record goalscorer Manuchekhr Dzhililov out with cancer and veteran midfielder Amirbek Juraboev injured, the team came in as a minnow on paper. But, playing as a unit, the team, ranked 106, punched way above its weight, reaching the quarterfinals with a win against the United Arab Emirates — ranked 64 — on penalties.

Qatar, too, saw different leaders step up in different games, starting with Afif making runs along flanks and feeding long balls for set-pieces to captain Hassan Al-Haydos scoring the winner against China through a brilliant volley. Goalkeeper Meshaal

+ STAT PACK

2019 AFC Asian Cup

130 goals in 51 matches
Knockouts — 2
extra-time, 2 penalty
shootout
Stoppage time goals in
knockouts — 5 (2
decisive)

2023 AFC Asian Cup

132 goals in 51 matches
Knockouts — 1
extra-time, 4 penalty
shootout
Stoppage time goals in
knockouts — 8 (6
decisive)